Q+A

No 'Place Like Home'

Having recently received news that he'd won a National Award for the song 'Marenge To Wahin Jaakar', filmmaker and music director ***Vishal Bhardwaj*** *spoke to us about Covid, inequity and cinema*



INDIA PICTURE

Q. You've won national awards before, but does this one feel special in any way?

The subject of this song and the documentary [*1232 Kms*] makes it very special, also since the pandemic affected all of us in different ways. We are the privileged ones who did not have to face survival problems, but the story of the daily wagers and labourers, those who had to travel thousands of kilometres to reach their homes, was such a horrific and painful one. In fact, I felt guilty for being safe and happy with my family at home. The song I composed for this documentary [*1232 Kms*] was a catharsis.

Q. Covid has often left us feeling helpless. At some level, is 'Marenge To Wahin Jaakar' a reminder that we can all do better?

'Marenge To Wahin Jaakar' is a song that is diametrically opposite to the song from *Maachis*– 'Chhod Aaye Hum Wo Galiyan', which talks about leaving home in search of a better life. 'Marenge To Wahin Jaakar', on the other hand, says this is not worth it. Home is the place that matters the most.

Q. You're making *Khufiya* for Netflix. Has directing a spy thriller proved challenging in any way?

No, it was a treat. It brought back the child in me. It took me back to a time when we used to enjoy reading spy novels and espionage stories. It's the genre that I love the most.

Q. *Kuttey*, your son Aasmaan's directorial debut, releases on November 4. As both his father and producer, how hard a taskmaster have you been?

I've not been his taskmaster. On the contrary, I want to be his friend and his support, which I tried to be. I am also his co-writer. We wrote the script together. Sometimes we have different points of view, but that's the sign of a healthy, creative partnership.

- with Shreevatsa Nevatia